

UNDER THREAT

CORALS

Corals are vibrant invertebrates that build underwater reef colonies. Closely related to jellyfish and sea anemones, they share a common feature: tentacles around the mouth. The Zoological Survey of India (ZSI) says 309 coral species have been recorded in and around the proposed project area.

THE FEAR: Environmentalists caution that Galathea Bay in the southern part of Great Nicobar Island (GNI), where the port is set to come up, has a rich coral population. Corals play a critical role in the broader marine ecosystems of the Andaman Sea and Bay of Bengal. Their degradation could have far-reaching consequences for fisheries and ocean health.

THE RESPONSE: Citing ZSI data, MoEFCC says the Galathea Bay project area does not host coral populations. Still, as a precautionary measure, of the 20,668 coral colonies identified in nearby waters, 16,150 colonies within 15 metres of depth and in proximity to the project will be translocated. ZSI will monitor each translocated colony using GPS to track survival rates and long-term ecological recovery. Additionally, the 2.73 sq. km Meroe Island has been designated as a coral sanctuary.

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FORESTS

GNI has 103,870 ha. of tropical evergreen forests, both terrestrial and marine, which are home to 650 plant species, 13 per cent of which are endemic to the island; 32.5 per cent are not found in mainland India. GNI flora is distinct even from the Andaman islands. This is because of the insular nature of the territory, with even the islands being physically isolated from one another.



mound nests on the forest floor and is a keystone species for the island's fragile ecology. There are also the Nicobar Macaque, giant robber crabs, rare butterflies and orchids. Offshore, the coral reefs and surrounding waters are estimated to harbour over 245 rare species across 53 genera and 15 families of aquatic life.

Roaming the island's dense interiors are the Shompen, a hunter-gatherer tribe numbering barely 350, who have inhabited these forests for centuries and know relatively little of the outside world. There are also about 450 Nicobarese who were resettled after the 2004 tsunami destroyed their homes.

This pristine environment may now be in peril. Sparking concern is the controversial Rs 81,000 crore port and defence project, which was cleared by the Kolkata bench of National Green Tribunal (NGT) on February 16, taking it a step closer to realisation. The centrepiece of the Great Nicobar Island Project (GNIP) is a Rs 44,000 crore international container transhipment port in Galathea Bay, which the government claims will transform this remote outpost into a strategic linchpin astride one of the world's busiest shipping lanes. Other components of this 166 square kilometre mega project include a greenfield international airport, a 400 MW green power plant, and an eco-tourism and residential township designed to house up to 125,000 people. The airport is planned for dual civil-military use. But details of the defence project, including a possible naval base, were disclosed only to the NGT bench in a sealed envelope, and not made public for reasons of national security.